

The Writer's Craft, Grade 12

College Preparation

EWC4C

This course emphasizes knowledge and skills related to the craft of writing. Students will investigate models of effective writing; use a workshop approach to write a variety of works; and make considered decisions for improving the quality of their writing. They will also complete a creative or analytical independent study project and investigate opportunities for publication and for writing careers.

Prerequisite: English, Grade 11, College Preparation

Strands

The expectations in this course are organized into the following strands:

- A. Investigating Writing
- B. Practising Writing
- C. Reflecting On Writing

A. INVESTIGATING WRITING

OVERALL EXPECTATION

By the end of this course, students will:

1. **Writing, Writers, and the Writing Life:** demonstrate an understanding of writing as an art, a craft, and a career as they explore the work of a variety of Canadian and international writers.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Writing, Writers, and the Writing Life

By the end of this course, students will:

Writing Models

- 1.1 read a variety of teacher- and self-selected models of effective writing to become familiar with the art, craft, and world of writing (e.g., *keep a record of the works they read for this course; identify diverse cultural points of view and divergent perspectives on current issues in their reading; select from their reading one or two models that they could use to guide their own writing*)

Teacher prompts: “What form of writing do you find most appealing? Why?” “What contemporary writer have you enjoyed the most? Why?”

The Art and Craft of Writing

- 1.2 demonstrate an understanding of the art and craft of writing after examining interviews with and articles by writers about their writing practices, processes, and beliefs (e.g., *compare information about and comments provided by a variety of authors on their websites; describe what they have learned about writing after listening to and/or viewing a variety of interviews with authors, such as those on the CBC Radio show “Writers & Company”; ask a poet who has been invited to address the class about his or her writing practices and thoughts on the art and craft of writing*)

Teacher prompts: “What have you learned about the life of a freelance journalist from the articles you read in class?” “Based on the information available on this author’s website, what questions would you like to ask her about her experiences in becoming a writer?”

Elements of Form

- 1.3 analyse the ways in which writers use elements of form (e.g., *verse structure in poetry; stage directions in drama; character, setting, and point of view in fiction; headings and sidebars in magazine articles; charts and graphs in textbooks; colour, images, and fonts in advertisements*) to communicate meaning (e.g., *explain how an author uses details of time and place to establish setting; analyse the way a newspaper uses headings and photographs to convey information both overtly and implicitly; explain how the author of a personal essay uses expository writing and a narrative structure to communicate his or her central claim or thesis*)

Teacher prompts: “How does the point of view in the story affect the information that is provided to the reader?” “How has the angle taken by the reporter of this news story affected the choice of photograph that accompanies it?” “What do the direct quotations add to the article?”

Elements of Style

- 1.4 analyse the ways in which writers use elements of style (e.g., *diction, voice, tone, literary and/or rhetorical devices, sentence structure*) to communicate meaning (e.g., *compare the effect on the reader of the use of rhyme in one lyric poem and free verse in another; compare the journalistic styles used in radio, television, and Web-based news stories; explain how a first-person point of view in both fiction and non-fiction can affect the reader’s response to the work; analyse the use of metaphor in a story by an Aboriginal writer; explain how the use of dialect or non-standard English enhances the portrayal of a character or a setting*)

Teacher prompts: “Which words were particularly effective in describing the setting?” “How

did the author achieve a humorous tone in this children's story?" "What effect has the author achieved by varying line lengths in this poem?" "What effect does the author's use of repetition have in this essay?" "If the author had used rhetorical questions, would she have been more successful in engaging the reader?"

The Writer's Perspective

- 1.5** explain various ways in which works by selected writers from Canada and around the world are influenced by the writers' personal experiences, beliefs, and socio-cultural contexts (*e.g., explain how a popular novelist incorporates current issues into his or her work; identify themes that recur in the work of a favourite poet, and explain their connection to the poet's world; explain the influence of culture on the work of a contemporary writer from Europe, Asia, Africa, or South America; read the work of one or more contemporary Aboriginal writers and analyse the perspective that he or she has on a current issue*)

Teacher prompts: "What cultural issues are reflected in the work of this writer?" "What does this writer's work reveal about a political or historical situation?" "What ideas about Canadian identity are evident in this writer's work?"

The Writing Profession

- 1.6** research a variety of opportunities and/or careers in writing-related fields, and identify the skills needed to pursue them (*e.g., investigate the websites of a variety of Canadian writers', journalists', and publishers' associations to explore the range of writing opportunities in Canada and the skills needed for them; research and determine the qualifications needed for admittance to both postsecondary and community writing programs; interview a professional writer for local media about the education and/or experience required to reach his or her current position*)

Teacher prompts: "What steps should a young writer take to get his or her work published?" "What are the skills required for work in broadcast journalism? In print journalism? As an advertising copy writer?" "Which websites did you find that would be useful to a young writer who is interested in learning more about a career in journalism?" "What appeals to you about the writing life? What aspects of that life do not appeal to you?" "In which areas do you think there is likely to be a fairly steady demand for writers? Which types of writing are the least secure, in terms of a career?"

B. PRACTISING WRITING

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Exploring Ideas, Forms, and Styles:** generate and experiment with ideas about writing content, forms, and styles;
- 2. Drafting and Revising:** organize, draft, and revise their writing, employing forms and stylistic elements appropriate for their purpose and audience;
- 3. Editing, Proofreading, and Publishing:** use editing, proofreading, and publishing skills and strategies to refine and polish their work;
- 4. Collaborative Writing:** collaborate in the writing process with peers by generating ideas, responding to peers' work, and assessing peers' work in a workshop setting.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Exploring Ideas, Forms, and Styles

By the end of this course, students will:

Generating Ideas

- 1.1** generate and explore ideas for potential writing projects independently through reflection, reading, listening, viewing, and research (*e.g., develop a character who will deliver a short monologue; create the dialogue for a scene in a selected film after viewing the scene with the sound turned off; select and develop ideas from their journals to use in a poem; record facts from a mock press conference to use in writing a news article; read several reviews of a movie to find comments to use in a promotional poster for the movie; over the course of one week, write a series of "after-school" vignettes based on observations made at home, at the workplace, or in a local coffee shop or mall; read local and community newspapers to determine local issues, and choose one issue to explore in an article for the school newspaper*)

Teacher prompts: "Have you read anything interesting or unusual recently that has given you an idea to pursue for writing?" "What new idea for writing a poem have you discovered as a result of studying this poet's work?" "What ideas have emerged from your journal that you could use to develop the plot for a short story?" "Which of the ideas brainstormed by your group interests you as a topic for your personal essay?"

Experimenting With Forms and Styles

- 1.2** use text forms and stylistic elements in experimental ways to develop a personal writing style (*e.g., create a verbal/visual collage on a topic of interest; write a text that emulates the style and structure of a published model; rewrite a newspaper article as a dramatic script; incorporate different text forms, such as a personal letter, a poem, a newspaper article, and/or a photograph, into a short story they are writing; develop a list of various kinds of figurative language that they can draw on for writing projects; create a concrete poem inspired by a key passage from a literary work; write a commentary on a local issue using an ironic or satirical approach*)

Teacher prompts: "What adaptations would be necessary to create a radio play from a short story?" "What key ideas from this literary work will you transfer to your poem? Which words suit your purpose, and how will you arrange them? What effect are you trying to create?"

2. Drafting and Revising

By the end of this course, students will:

Drafting: Focus on Content

- 2.1** select and organize ideas and information to draft texts appropriate for the purpose and audience (*e.g., draft the outline for a narrative text based on a series of personal or professional*

photographs; write a monologue based on a character developed collaboratively by a small group; organize ideas from entries they have made in their journals to draft an article for a school newspaper; adapt a children's story for a teenage audience; write a script based on overheard conversations; draft a letter applying for a job as a teen columnist with a community newspaper, highlighting their skills and experience as a writer)

Teacher prompts: "How will you convert the conversational clips you recorded in your writer's notebook into scripted dialogue?" "Which pieces of information collected by your group in researching this topic will you use to develop your essay?" "How will you arrange your imagery to best convey the effect you would like to achieve in this poem?" "Which of the approaches to introducing your topic will most effectively engage your readers' interest?" "How will you organize your letter of application to most effectively communicate your strengths as a candidate?"

Drafting: Focus on Form and Style

2.2 use appropriate text forms and stylistic elements to communicate ideas and experiences effectively in their writing (*e.g., use a journalistic tone in writing a feature article for a community newspaper; write a song lyric, incorporating appropriate imagery; use persuasive rhetorical devices in writing an editorial on a contemporary and/or controversial social issue*)

Teacher prompts: "Where could you add an anecdote in your essay to more effectively engage your audience?" "How would you need to change your article if you were writing for a different audience?" "Could you incorporate more description to strengthen the impression you want to convey? Where would it be most effective?" "What words give your article a journalistic tone?" "How would you change the way you write this story if it were intended for older children?"

Revising

2.3 revise drafts by reviewing and refining content, form, and stylistic elements to produce clear, coherent, and effective written work (*e.g., review their work to see if arguments are well developed and supported by specific evidence, and make changes where necessary; review their paragraphs for a variety of sentence beginnings; review their sentence lengths for variety; review their conclusions, and make changes where necessary; review their work to see if changes are needed to help readers clearly*

visualize the setting; review the feedback and assessments provided by the teacher and their peers, and incorporate suggestions where appropriate)

Teacher prompts: "Does your essay need more specific evidence to convince readers of your position?" "Is the conclusion to your short story forced or contrived?" "Do the images you have used in your layout effectively suggest the impression you intend to convey?" "Is the level of your diction appropriate for the purpose and audience of this letter?" "Do you think the assessment you received from the group is valuable? Have they understood or misunderstood your intentions?" "Which of the suggestions offered by your peers in the workshop session have you decided to use in your revision?"

3. Editing, Proofreading, and Publishing

By the end of this course, students will:

Editing and Proofreading

3.1 edit and proofread their written work, applying the conventions of spelling, usage, punctuation, and grammar correctly and appropriately (*e.g., have a partner read their work aloud to help identify possible sentence errors and awkward or confusing wording; check their spelling and punctuation, using a highlighter pen to mark possible errors to be reviewed; use electronic grammar and spell-check programs to identify possible errors; check that they have used quotation marks correctly*)

Teacher prompts: "When you read your work to a partner, can you detect gaps in the content, omitted words or phrases, or errors in grammar or punctuation?" "How do you know if a computer-identified error is in fact an error, and whether the suggested correction is accurate?" "Have you found words or phrases in your work that you think should be reconsidered? How could you identify better ones?" "When you listened to your work being read aloud, which words or phrases sounded awkward or confusing?"

Publishing

3.2 produce polished written work, using a variety of effective presentation features appropriate for the purpose and intended audience (*e.g., use an easy-to-follow layout and appealing visuals to complement a story written for elementary students or preschool children; use appropriate and effective fonts, design elements,*

and layout to create a professional-looking brochure, promoting a topic, product, or service of their choice)

Teacher prompts: “What design features and fonts would best enhance your submission to the class literary anthology?” “How are you planning to format and package your writing portfolio for college admission purposes?” “How would the cover page for your short story change if you were submitting it to be used in an elementary classroom as opposed to submitting it to a literary magazine for publication?”

4. Collaborative Writing

By the end of this course, students will:

Generating Ideas Collaboratively

- 4.1** generate and explore ideas for potential writing projects collaboratively through brainstorming and other discussions with a partner or as a group in a workshop setting (e.g., *develop a proposal for a small-group writing project; outline, with a partner, three possible ways to develop a personal essay; collaborate with others in a workshop setting to create four different introductions to a short story based on the same character; brainstorm to develop lists of heroes, villains, time periods, conflicts, and possible first lines as a way to generate ideas for creative writing*)

Teacher prompts: “What new ideas have you acquired for developing your story as a result of today’s workshop?” “What images from the Graffiti activity could you use to strengthen the effect of your poem?” “What examples did the group generate that could be used to show the impact the event described in your personal essay had on you?” “What options for your thesis did you come up with by brainstorming with your partner?”

Providing Feedback to Peers

- 4.2** provide constructive feedback to peers on works in progress by working with a partner or as a group in a workshop setting (e.g., *propose possible endings for a peer’s short story; make suggestions aimed at improving specific aspects of a peer’s draft of a personal essay, such as using more powerful adjectives, reorganizing a description of events, or correcting grammatical errors; compose a written response to a peer, replying to specific concerns he or she has identified in a piece of his or her writing*)

Teacher prompts: “What did you hear or notice in the student’s work that impressed you?” “What makes this student’s work particularly original?” “What is your initial impression of the character, based on the first page of the story?” “What suggestions can you make to improve your partner’s writing? How can you be helpful without being overly critical?”

Assessing Peers’ Work

- 4.3** assess peers’ written drafts, working with a partner or as a group in a workshop setting, to aid peers in their revision process (e.g., *assess a peer’s work using a class-constructed rubric or checklist, and explain their assessment to him or her; discuss the merits of suggestions for revision received from peers in their writing workshop*)

Teacher prompts: “What could you tell your peer that would encourage her confidence in her writing skills?” “What has your group identified as the strengths of your classmate’s project?” “Based on the criteria discussed in class and your classmate’s work, what suggestions for improvement will your group offer him?”

C. REFLECTING ON WRITING

OVERALL EXPECTATION

By the end of this course, students will:

1. **Metacognition:** identify their strengths as writers and areas where they could improve, and assess the growth and development of their own writing style.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Metacognition

By the end of this course, students will:

Understanding Their Creative Choices

- 1.1 identify and explain specific creative choices they have made during the writing process to help them better understand the art of writing (e.g., *explain why they chose to use specific literary devices in specific works; identify and explain how the revision process helped them improve one of their pieces; explain why they chose to accept specific suggestions for improvement offered by classmates*)

Teacher prompts: “Where in your writing did you try something new? Were you pleased with the result? Why?” “How does your work reflect your personal experience?” “How is this piece of writing unlike any other writing you have done in the past?” “What advice have you received from your peers that has helped you the most as a writer?”

Understanding Their Perspectives and Biases

- 1.2 explain how their own beliefs, values, and experiences are revealed in their writing (e.g., *identify examples of allusions to popular culture in their work; identify and explain a specific example in their writing of where they have drawn on their personal background, experiences, or cultural influences to develop an argument; identify two pieces of writing that reveal, overtly or implicitly, their own cultural expectations; explain what they think their writing would reveal about them to someone from another planet*)

Teacher prompts: “To what extent do your personal values inform the content of your writing? Are there things you are not comfortable writing about?” “Where in your writing have you expressed a point of view

that could be controversial?” “To what extent is this piece of writing based directly on your personal experiences?”

Planning to Improve

- 1.3 identify their areas of strength and weakness as writers, and the steps they can take to improve their own writing (e.g., *explain the difficulties they encountered while writing a specific piece, and identify specific ways they could avoid experiencing those difficulties again; describe how they plan to develop a specific part of their writing process that needs improvement*)

Teacher prompts: “What one strategy could you incorporate into your writing process to improve your writing significantly?” “What has been your greatest challenge in writing this year? What are you planning to do to overcome that challenge in the future?” “Which activities conducted in class this year have helped you to develop your confidence as a writer?”

Demonstrating Growth

- 1.4 select samples of their writing that document their growth as writers for inclusion in a portfolio (e.g., *prepare a portfolio of their work, showing their development as writers, to present to their classmates, the teacher, their parents, or a postsecondary institution*)

Teacher prompts: “Which of your pieces are you most proud of, and why?” “Which pieces of your work demonstrate that you have overcome a difficulty you were experiencing as a writer?” “What have you learned about yourself as a writer that you didn’t know or understand before taking this course?” “What impact has this writing course had on your writing in other courses?”